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promote the well being of the state. He advocated maintenance of perfect balance between State management and people's welfare through trading activities.

Commerce and Trade in North India

India was prosperous even during the medieval period from 12th to 16th centuries despite political upheavals. Balban was the first sultan who paved the way in the dense forest and helped traders and their commercial caravans to move from one market place to others. Alauddin Khilji brought the price to a very low ebb. He encouraged import of foreign goods from Persia and subsidised the goods. Arabs were dominant players in India's foreign trade. They never discouraged Indian traders like Tamils, Gujaratis, etc.. The Trade between the coastal ports were in the hands and Marwaris and Gujiratis. The overland trade with central and west Asia was in the hands of Multanis who were Hindus and Khurasanis who were Afghans, Iranians and so on. During Sultanate period, trade flourished due to the establishment of currency system based on silver and copper. Moorish traveller described the teeming market of big cities in the Gangetic plains, Malwar, Gujarat and South India. The important trade centres were Delhi, Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Sonar, Sonargoon, Jaunpur, Lahore and so on. The burgeoning foreign trade led to the development of market place in the towns and villages. India's handicraft commanded a good foreign market. India imported horses, dry fruits, precious stones, glassware, high grade textiles, raw silk, corals, scented oil, velvets, etc.. from Kabul, Arabia, Europe, West Asia and China. Indian products were exported to East Africa, Malaya, China and Far East. Trade was conducted through overland roots with Afghanistan, Central Asia and Persia India conducted foreign trade via land route with Quetta, Khyber pass, Iraq and Bukhara. The traders of Malabar, Gujarat and foreign settlers in the ports of Calicut, Khumbat and Mangalore controlled a major business sector in port cities.



POOMPUHAR

The southern Coromandel Coast mostly within the territory of Tamilnadu state is thick with history.This history is not only of the European colonization but goes back to the ancient times when many places along the coast were centres of international trade. One such place which is said to have flourished from 200 BC onwards is Poompuhar. The seaside town which was once the second capital of the Chola Dynasty and a major centre of international trade with both eastern and western people. Silk appears to be a major item of exports from here. The ancient port as destroyed and is now found by the archaeologists submerged off the coast for up to 5 km. Erosion of land or a Tsunami was cited as possible causes.